

Autocrats Before Autocracy: A Non-Tautological Measure of Democratic Backsliding*

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Abstract

Do autocratic-mandated leaders erode democratic institutions, and through what channels? To answer these questions, I construct a new database of autocratic executives (Prime Ministers, Presidents) across 62 competitive democracies from 1945 to 2025, using an ex-ante definition based on party campaign manifestos scored by a large language model for the share of content devoted to autocratic rhetoric. First, I show that the election of an autocratic-mandated leader strongly predicts whether a country transitions into autocracy within the following decade, under two independent regime classifications. Second, using local-projections and heterogeneity-robust difference-in-differences, I show that once in power these leaders weaken democratic institutions and judicial constraints on the executive gradually and cumulatively without reversion. They do so through executive non-compliance with the courts and court packing, rather than outright purges of sitting judges, alongside rising government and self-censorship of the media and harassment of journalists. Together the results show that autocratic-mandated leaders are constrained by existing institutional guardrails at first but wear them down over time, and that this trajectory is, to a meaningful degree, visible in their campaign rhetoric before it unfolds.

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Preliminary Draft

Comments welcome.

This paper is a preliminary draft. The one component still outstanding is a human validation of the language-model manifesto scores: trained coders will independently score a stratified sample of manifestos on the same six dimensions, blind to the model’s output, allowing me to report inter-rater reliability and human–model agreement and to bound the measure’s error rate—including on the borderline cases discussed in Section 3.5.

“There is no liberty if the judiciary power be not separated from the legislative and executive.”

— Montesquieu, *The Spirit of the Laws* (1748)

“The courts are packed or intimidated into submission... The erosion of democracy takes place piecemeal, often in ways that seem ‘legal’.”

— Steven Levitsky & Daniel Ziblatt, *How Democracies Die* (2019)

1 Introduction

A long literature on autocracy emphasizes repression, elite bargains, and patronage as methods of autocratic capture. Yet a defining feature of twenty-first-century autocratization is subtler: rather than ruling *outside* the law, modern autocrats have learned to rule *through* it. They reshape courts, politicize judicial appointments, erode judicial independence, and insulate executive action from legal challenge. Hungary, Turkey, Poland, and Venezuela did not abolish their judiciaries and press—they subordinated them. In April 2010 Viktor Orbán won a two-thirds majority in the Hungarian parliament and called the result “revolution at the ballot box.” Within eighteen months his government had written a new constitution, lowered the mandatory retirement age for judges from seventy to sixty-two in a single stroke that removed roughly a tenth of the senior judiciary, and enlarged and reshaped the Constitutional Court that might have stopped him. No tanks appeared in the streets and no election was cancelled. The courts were still open, the newspapers still published, and each step was passed into law by an elected legislature. This is the characteristic form of twenty-first-century autocratization: not rule outside the law but rule through it.

Establishing that autocratic leaders *cause* this institutional erosion, rather than merely coincide with it, runs into a basic obstacle: how one defines an “autocratic” leader. Classifications built on what leaders *do* once in office (i.e. packing courts, jailing opponents, subverting elections) are mechanically related to the outcomes they are meant to explain. Coding a leader as autocratic *because* they captured the judiciary and media, and then estimating the effect of autocratic leaders on these institutions, is a tautology, not a causal finding. Any ex-post measure of autocratic behavior embeds the outcome in the treatment.

I break this circularity by classifying leaders *before* they take office, using what they campaigned on rather than what they did ex-ante. I construct a new database of autocratic-mandated executives from party campaign manifestos from Comparative Manifesto Project (CMP) (Lehmann et al. 2025) corpus, covering winning parties across 62 competitive democracies. Enhancing the typical CMP scoring methodology¹, using a large language model, I score each manifesto for the share of quasi-sentences expressing autocratic rhetoric across six dimensions grounded in Levitsky and Ziblatt (2019) and the Varieties of Democracy

¹The current CMP database does not have an official autocracy index. It’s mostly oriented on policy orientation. The CMP database is human-coded but offers a separate trained text-analysis model to reproduce their policy orientation scoring results.

(Coppedge et al. 2026) coding framework: (i) delegitimization of opponents, (ii) concentration of executive power, (iii) intimidation and violence, (iv) suppression of media and civil society, (v) judicial capture, and (vi) electoral subversion. Because manifestos are written and scored before any institutional outcome is realized, the resulting measure is *logically prior* to judicial erosion: “ran on an authoritarian platform” and “courts later lost independence” are distinct events, measured from independent sources. A leader is treated when a non-incumbent party wins office on a manifesto whose autocratic-rhetoric share exceeds a threshold (baseline 5%); restricting treatment to challengers isolates the first year a new leader takes power rather than the continuation of an established regime.

I validate the measure against two independent autocracy datasets. The share of autocratic rhetoric in a winning manifesto strongly predicts whether a country subsequently transitions into autocracy, as recorded separately by V-Dem and Polity5—a leader’s campaign language forecasts the institutional trajectory that follows, before that trajectory unfolds.

I then estimate the dynamic effect of an autocratic-mandate win on democratic institutions. Because treatment is staggered, repeated, and heterogeneous in timing across countries, conventional two-way fixed-effects estimators are biased (Goodman-Bacon 2021; De Chaisemartin and D’Haultfœuille 2020). To avoid these issues, my main specification is a local-projections difference-in-differences design (Dube et al. 2025), which traces the cumulative effect at each horizon relative to the year before the election and uses pre-treatment horizons as direct placebo tests of parallel trends. I confirm robustness with the heterogeneity-robust estimator of De Chaisemartin and D’Haultfœuille (2020). The outcomes are V-Dem’s expert-coded Electoral Democracy Index and Judicial Constraints on the Executive, estimated across Comparative Manifesto Project countries from 1960 to 2024.

The results show that democratic institutions bend rather than break at the moment of the shock, then erode steadily. Pre-treatment trends are flat, ruling out pre-existing decline among treated countries. Following an autocratic-mandate win, electoral democracy and judicial constraints decline gradually and cumulatively over the subsequent decade, with no recovery—consistent with the view that institutional guardrails constrain newly elected autocrats initially but are worn down over time. The same shock propagates beyond the judiciary into the information environment, weakening media independence, raising government censorship, and increasing the harassment of journalists.

The paper makes two primary contributions. First, it introduces a non-tautological, ex-ante measure of executive autocratic tendencies, built from campaign manifestos and validated against independent autocracy datasets, offering the democratic-backsliding literature a treatment variable that is logically prior to the outcomes it explains. Second, it provides causally-credible estimates of the effect of autocratic-mandate leaders on democratic and judicial institutions using modern, heterogeneity-robust dynamic estimators.

The remainder of the paper is organized as follows. Section 2 reviews the related literature. Section 3 describes the CMP corpus, the LLM scoring pipeline, and its validation. Section 4 presents the empirical design. Section 5 reports the main results and robustness. Section 6 concludes.

2 Related Literature

This paper speaks to four strands of scholarship.

First, it builds on the political science of democratic backsliding and the “third wave of autocratization.” A consensus holds that the contemporary threat to democracy is no longer the sudden coup but gradual, executive-led erosion from within, in which incumbents dismantle horizontal constraints (i.e. electoral commissions, the judiciary, and the media) while preserving a democratic facade, a pattern that intensified after 2010 and in which the deterioration of judicial independence is among the earliest indicators (Bermeo 2016; Levitsky and Ziblatt 2019; Lührmann and Lindberg 2019; Haggard and Kaufman 2021). A parallel argument in economics emphasizes that modern autocrats rely less on mass repression than on the manipulation of information and the selective use of legal instruments to neutralize opponents at low reputational cost (Guriev and Treisman 2019; Guriev and Papaioannou 2022). Furthermore, courts are widely modeled as endogenous to political bargaining: judicial independence lets legislatures commit credibly to interest groups and supplies the focal points that coordinate elite resistance to executive overreach, and is most valuable, on an insurance logic, to actors uncertain of retaining power (Landes and Posner 1975; Weingast 1997; Hanssen 2004). This implies that autocratizers, having resolved that uncertainty in their favor, have strong incentives to dismantle the institutions that protected them in opposition. Consistent with this, a comparative literature shows that autocrats often do not abolish courts but instrumentalize them — maintaining judiciaries that resolve disputes and lend a veneer of legality to repression — and that judicial behavior is itself strategic, with courts empowered to protect prior elites becoming targets for packing and purges once those elites are displaced (Ginsburg and Moustafa 2008; Gretchen Helmke 2002; Hirschl 2009).

Second, it connects to the institutional economics of development and the downstream consequences of the institutional change. A foundational literature links contract enforcement and constraints on government to long-run performance and provides causal evidence that property-rights institutions shape comparative development (North 1990; Acemoglu et al. 2001), while the law-and-finance tradition ties legal origin, court efficiency, and judicial independence to investor protection, financial development, and lower corruption (La Porta et al. 1998; Djankov et al. 2003; La Porta et al. 2004). Because weakened courts lower the cost of repression, their capture plausibly cascades beyond growth into the prosecution of opponents, the harassment of journalists, and unchallenged electoral irregularities (Guriev and Treisman 2019), motivating the breadth of outcomes I examine.

Third, it contributes to the measurement of democratic change and, methodologically, to its credible estimation. Binary classifications capture discrete threshold crossings to democracy (Cheibub et al. 2010; Boix et al. 2013; Acemoglu et al. 2019), while continuous, expert-coded indices capture gradual within-regime decline (Coppedge et al. 2026; Marshall and Gurr 2020); I draw on both V-Dem and Polity5 so that conclusions do not hinge on a single operationalization. Yet despite the convergence of theory on courts as a primary target of autocrats, the causal effect of autocratization on judicial independence has not been estimated with methods robust to heterogeneous treatment timing, with prior work relying on cross-sectional variation or case studies (La Porta et al. 2004; Hanssen 2004; Ginsburg and Moustafa 2008; Gretchen Helmke 2002). This paper fills that gap.

Fourth, it contributes to the economics of political leaders. A literature exploiting as-good-as-random leadership transitions (i.e. deaths in office and assassinations) establishes that individual leaders causally shape national growth and the likelihood of institutional change, including transitions between democracy and autocracy (Jones and Olken 2005; Jones and Olken 2009), with leader characteristics such as education and competence also mattering for economic performance (Besley et al. 2011; Besley and Kudamatsu 2007). Most directly, recent work shows that populist leaders (distinct but not unrelated to autocrats) systematically produce worse macroeconomic outcomes and erodes institutional constraints once in office (Funke et al. 2023; Guriev and Papaioannou 2022). This paper complements that agenda in two ways: it identifies the relevant leader type *ex ante*, from campaign manifestos rather than from realized behavior, and it traces the dynamic effect specifically onto judicial and democratic institutions.

3 Data

The empirical analysis combines three ingredients: a corpus of election manifestos, a new measure of autocratic rhetoric that I construct from those manifestos with a large language model, and standard cross-national indices of democratic and judicial institutions that serve as outcomes. This section describes each in turn, with particular attention to the scoring pipeline, since the measure is the paper’s central methodological contribution.

3.1 Election Manifestos

The source text is the CMP version MPDS2025a, which compiles the full text of party platforms for elections across more than fifty competitive democracies from 1945 to the present. The CMP is the standard text-as-data source in comparative political economy: its manifestos are the authoritative statement of what each party promises at a given election, written before the party takes office.

The unit of analysis is the government-forming party at each election that supplied the head of government afterward, which is not always the largest party by seats. I identify the winner using a four-layer procedure: ParlGov (Döring and Manow 2024) cabinet records (the party holding the prime ministership) where available; the V-Party (Lindberg et al. 2022) dataset for countries ParlGov does not cover; a set of manual assignments for post-2019 elections and known coalition or coding discrepancies; and a seat-share fallback otherwise. This yields 554 election winners whose full manifesto text is available. Manifestos are scored in their original language.

3.2 Measuring Autocratic Rhetoric: A Two-Pass LLM Pipeline

Rather than assign each manifesto a single holistic severity score, I measure autocratic rhetoric as a *proportion*: the share of a manifesto’s content devoted to autocratic appeals. The unit is the *quasi-sentence*, one clause expressing a single political idea, borrowed directly from the CMP’s own coding scheme, in which human coders classify quasi-sentences into policy categories and report category shares. I apply the same proportional logic to

autocratic content, using a large language model as the coder. The scoring framework is grounded in two sources: the four behavioural indicators of autocratic parties in Levitsky and Ziblatt (2019), and V-Dem’s conceptualization of autocratization through the erosion of judicial independence, executive constraints, electoral integrity, and civil society.

All scoring uses Anthropic’s Claude Haiku 4.5 (`claude-haiku-4-5`) at temperature zero, which makes the scoring deterministic and reproducible; a larger model, Claude Sonnet 4.6, is used as a fallback only when a response fails to parse after repeated attempts. Manifestos exceeding the model’s practical context are split into overlapping character chunks and recombined as described below. The pipeline runs in three passes.

Pass 1: Loose binary screen. All 554 manifestos pass through a deliberately permissive filter whose only job is to separate ordinary policy platforms from manifestos that warrant detailed scoring. A manifesto is flagged ($label = 1$) if it contains *any* signal of institutional-erosion rhetoric, even weak or in passing, such as:

- framing opponents, the judiciary, the media, or civil society as corrupt, illegitimate, criminal, or enemies of the people;
- rhetoric implying that only this party or leader represents the true will of the nation;
- calls for strong, decisive, or unobstructed executive leadership;
- criticism of courts, electoral bodies, or oversight agencies as captured or in need of fundamental reform;
- nationalist framing that identifies internal enemies; or
- proposals to change the composition, mandate, or independence of courts, media regulators, electoral commissions, or prosecutorial bodies.

A manifesto is screened out ($label = 0$) only if it is an entirely standard policy platform with no political-identity framing, or if it explicitly commits to strengthening judicial independence, press freedom, and electoral integrity. The prompt instructs the model to flag when in doubt, because a false positive is corrected cheaply at the next stage whereas a false negative permanently fixes the score to zero. Long manifestos are processed in 80,000-character chunks under OR logic, so that one flagged chunk flags the manifesto and scanning stops at the first flag. The model returns `{"label", "summary"}`. Of the 554 manifestos, 335 (60%) are flagged and 219 (40%) are screened out; screened-out manifestos receive a score of zero on every dimension and on the overall measure. See Appendix A.1 for Prompt 1 text.

Pass 2: Autocratic share. A second pass on the 335 flagged manifestos estimates a single *union* proportion: the share of quasi-sentences containing autocratic rhetoric of any kind across all six dimensions of autocratic rhetoric (Table 1), where a quasi-sentence counts once even if it touches several dimensions. This union share, which I denote $s_{i,t}$ and call the *autocratic share*, is the paper’s primary treatment variable. Estimating it directly, rather than

summing the six dimension scores, which would double-count overlapping quasi-sentences, yields a clean measure of total autocratic content bounded in $[0, 1]$. See Appendix A.2 for Prompt 2.

Table 1: Dimensions of Autocratic Rhetoric

Dimension	Source	Content scored
D1 Opponent delegitimation	L&Z (2)	Framing rivals as criminals, traitors, foreign agents, or enemies of the people; portraying any loss as fraud; claiming sole authentic representation of the nation.
D2 Power concentration	L&Z (1)	Expanding executive authority at the expense of constitutional checks: removing oversight bodies, bypassing parliament, extending term limits, rewriting the constitution to entrench the party.
D3 Intimidation & violence	L&Z (3)	Tolerating or encouraging violence or intimidation against opponents, journalists, judges, or minorities; prosecution framed as settling scores.
D4 Media & civil-society suppression	L&Z (4)	Attacking independent media, NGOs, or civil society as corrupt or foreign-funded, and calling to restrict or subordinate them to state control.
D5 Judicial capture	V-Dem	Attacking or restructuring courts, judges, or prosecutors: packing or purging courts, overriding rulings, subordinating prosecutors to the executive.
D6 Electoral subversion	V-Dem	Undermining confidence in electoral institutions or changing electoral rules to benefit the party: advance fraud claims, restructuring electoral commissions, restricting suffrage.

“L&Z” denotes the corresponding behavioural indicator in Levitsky and Ziblatt (2019); “V-Dem” denotes the institutional channel in the V-Dem framework. See Appendix A.2 for the text for Prompt 2.

Aggregation and the resulting measure. For manifestos processed in multiple chunks, dimension proportions and the autocratic share are recombined as a length-weighted average, $\sum_k p_k c_k / \sum_k c_k$, where p_k is the proportion in chunk k and c_k its character length, so that longer passages receive proportionate weight. Manifestos screened out at Pass 1 are assigned $s_{i,t} = 0$. The result is a single autocratic-share score for all 554 winners, together with the six underlying dimension scores. The distribution is right-skewed: 33% of manifestos score above zero, the median non-zero score is about 0.02, and the maximum is 0.18 (Fidesz,

Hungary, 2018). The measure thus identifies a modest set of manifestos in which autocratic rhetoric is a recurring theme, against a large mass of ordinary platforms.

3.3 From Score to Treatment

Treatment is assigned only to *challenger* wins, elections in which the winning party differs from the previous election’s winner in that country. Incumbent re-elections are excluded even when the manifesto scores highly, because the object of interest is the entry of a *new* autocratic-mandate leader, not the continuation of an established government. After this restriction there are 102 elections with a non-zero autocratic share across 48 countries. I use the measure in two forms: as a continuous treatment intensity, $s_{i,t}$, and as a binary indicator $\mathbf{1}\{s_{i,t} > \kappa\}$ at a transparent threshold, with $\kappa = 0.05$ as the baseline.

3.4 Outcome Data: V-Dem and Polity

The institutional outcomes come from the Varieties of Democracy (V-Dem) project (Coppedge et al. 2026), which provides expert-coded, cross-national indices of democratic institutions. The two main outcomes are the *Electoral Democracy Index*, a $[0, 1]$ measure of Dahl’s pol-yarchy capturing free and fair elections, freedom of expression, associational autonomy, and suffrage; and the *Judicial Constraints on the Executive Index*, a $[0, 1]$ measure of the extent to which the executive respects the constitution and complies with the judiciary, and the judiciary is able to act independently.

For the predictive-validity exercise (Section 4.1) and for robustness, I additionally use two categorical regime classifications. V-Dem’s Regimes of the World indicator (*v2x_regime*) places each country-year in one of four categories, with the lower two (closed and electoral autocracy) defining autocracy. Polity5 (Marshall and Gurr 2020) provides the composite *polity2* score on a -10 to $+10$ scale; following standard practice I treat $polity2 \geq 6$ as democracy, so that falling below six marks the loss of democratic status. The two classifications are built on different methodologies, and using both guards against any result being an artifact of a single coding scheme. Because Polity5 omits microstates and ends in 2018, its coverage is somewhat narrower than V-Dem’s.

The estimation sample is the panel of CMP countries over 1960–2024, the period over which manifesto, institutional, and regime data overlap.

3.5 Descriptive Statistics

Table 2 summarizes the database. The corpus comprises 554 government-forming party manifestos across 62 countries from 1945 to 2025. The autocratic-rhetoric share is, by construction and in fact, a sparse and right-skewed measure: the median manifesto scores zero, roughly one third (33%) score above zero, and the mean is 0.012 with a maximum of 0.180. In substantive terms, autocratic appeals are absent or negligible in most ordinary platforms and concentrated in a modest set of manifestos, so that the measure is designed to isolate that tail rather than to spread mass across the corpus.

Panel B describes the treatment used in the dynamic analysis. After the challenger restriction (Section 3.3), there are 102 elections with a positive autocratic share, spread

across 48 countries, with a mean score of 0.039 among these events. At the thresholds used for the binary specifications, 48, 24, and 18 events lie above 0.03, 0.05, and 0.07 respectively. The events are therefore numerous enough to identify cross-country dynamic effects while remaining a small and selective minority of all elections.

Table 2: Summary Statistics: The Autocratic-Rhetoric Database

	Mean	SD	Median	Max	$N_{>0}$
<i>Panel A. Autocratic-rhetoric share</i>					
Autocratic share s	0.012	0.024	0.000	0.180	182
<i>Panel B. Treatment (challenger-restricted)</i>					
Treatment events ($s > 0$)	102, across 48 countries				
Mean s among events	0.039				
Events with $s > 0.03$ / > 0.05 / > 0.07	48 / 24 / 18				

The sample is 554 government-forming party manifestos across 62 countries, 1945–2025. Panel A describes the large-language-model scores over all winners; $N_{>0}$ is the number of manifestos with a positive score (the median manifesto scores zero on the overall measure). Panel C describes the treatment after the challenger restriction (incumbent re-elections set to zero), i.e. the events that identify the dynamic estimates.

The cases that anchor the upper tail lend the measure face validity. Table 3 lists the highest-scoring manifestos: the single highest is Fidesz’s 2018 platform in Hungary (0.18), followed at 0.12 by a cluster of manifestos widely regarded as paradigmatic of contemporary backsliding, namely Fidesz again in 2010 and 2022, Bolsonaro’s 2018 campaign in Brazil, Zelensky’s Servant of the People in 2019, the Gaullists in 1973 France, and parties in Russia and Bosnia-Herzegovina. That the measure independently surfaces exactly the cases the qualitative literature treats as canonical, from text alone, is reassuring evidence that it is capturing autocratic content rather than noise.

Table 3: Highest-Scoring Manifestos

Country	Party (leader)	Year	s
Hungary	Fidesz–KDNP (Orbán)	2018	0.18
Hungary	Fidesz–KDNP (Orbán)	2010	0.12
Hungary	Fidesz–KDNP (Orbán)	2022	0.12
Brazil	Social Liberal Party (Bolsonaro)	2018	0.12
Ukraine	Servant of the People (Zelensky)	2019	0.12
France	Gaullists (UDR)	1973	0.12
Russia	Our Home–Russia	1995	0.12
Russia	Unity	1999	0.12
Bosnia-Herzegovina	SNSD (Dodik)	2006	0.12

Manifestos with the highest overall autocratic-rhetoric share s . Scores are length-weighted union proportions across the six dimensions (Section 3.2).

The appearance of Servant of the People among the highest-scoring manifestos (Table 3) illustrates a genuine and inherent limitation of any text-based, ex-ante measure. Manifestos record promises rather than actions, and the language of anti-corruption and anti-incumbent reform is common to both reformist and genuinely autocratic platforms. Distinguishing a pledge to fight corruption by reforming the courts from a plan to capture the courts under the cover of fighting corruption is difficult from text alone, often for a careful human reader and not only for an automated one. Zelensky’s 2019 platform is a clean example: it proposed (in translation) to “consolidate all branches of power” and to “reload” the judiciary, language that is lexically close to a program of judicial capture even though the party is not commonly regarded as autocratic. The measure therefore records stated intent with noise, and is best understood as a probabilistic signal rather than a deterministic classifier. This is precisely what the predictive-validity results bear out: a manifesto above the autocratic-rhetoric threshold is associated with roughly a nineteen percent probability of a subsequent transition to autocracy (Section 4.1), an elevated but far from certain risk. To confirm that no single misclassified case of this kind drives the main estimates, I report a leave-one-country-out exercise in which each treated country is dropped in turn (Section 5).

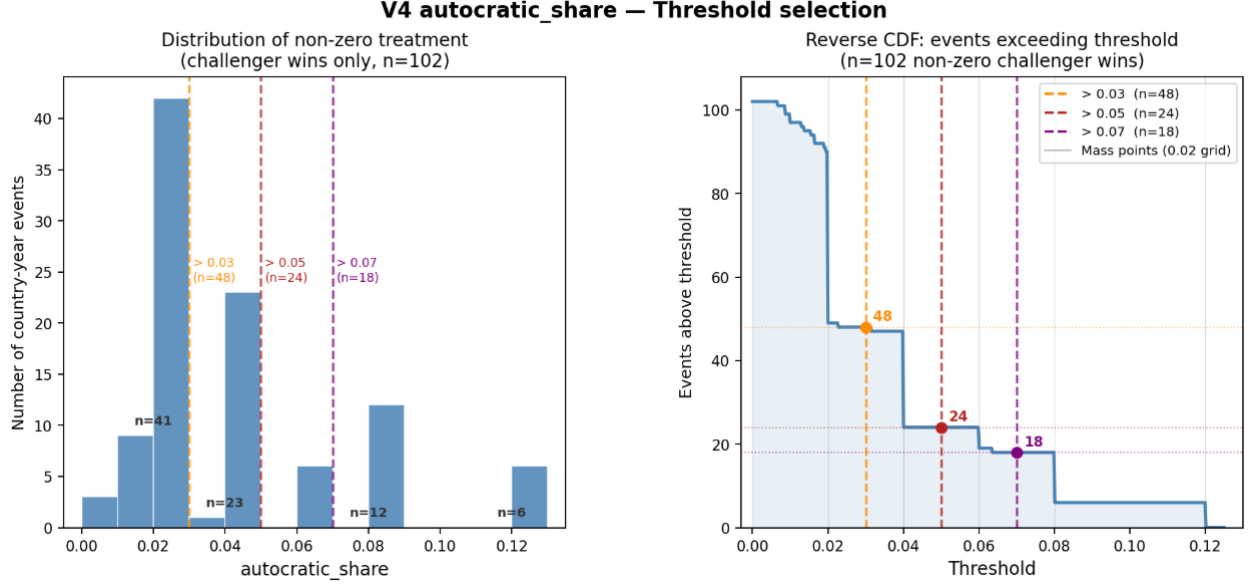


Figure 1: Distribution of the non-zero autocratic-rhetoric share among challenger wins. Left: histogram; right: number of events above each candidate threshold.

Figure 1 plots this treatment distribution directly, restricted to the 102 challenger wins with a non-zero score, and motivates the thresholds used in the binary specifications. The left panel makes the sparsity and right skew visible: the mass concentrates at the low end, falls on a coarse grid in roughly two-hundredths increments, and thins into a short tail toward the maximum, so that genuinely autocratic platforms are scarce even among the manifestos that register any signal at all. The right panel traces how many events survive each candidate cutoff. Two features of the shape guide the choice of threshold. First, because the score is quantized, the binary cutoffs are placed in the gaps between clusters rather than on top of them; the baseline at 0.05 in particular falls in an empty region, so that no event sits close enough to the line for small scoring error to move it across, and the binary treatment is correspondingly insensitive to the precise calibration of the model. Second, raising the cutoff trades sample size for a more sharply autocratic set of events, a trade-off that reappears in the results, where the estimated erosion grows stronger at the higher, more selective thresholds and weaker at the most permissive one.

4 Empirical Strategy

4.1 Predictive Validity: Does Autocratic Rhetoric Predict Autocratization?

Before estimating the dynamic effects of an autocratic-mandate win, I validate the manifesto-based measure against actual regime outcomes. The question is simple: does the share of a winning party’s manifesto devoted to autocratic rhetoric predict whether its country transitions into autocracy over the next decade? This is a forecasting exercise, not a causal claim — the coefficients below measure predictive power, not treatment effects.

Unit and predictor. The unit of observation is an election: one row per government-forming party in country i at election year t . The predictor is the *autocratic-rhetoric share*, $s_{i,t} \in [0, 1]$, defined as the fraction of quasi-sentences in the winning manifesto that express autocratic content. It is subject to the challenger restriction, so $s_{i,t} = 0$ for incumbent re-elections. Alongside the continuous share I define binary indicators for the share exceeding a threshold,

$$T_{i,t}(\kappa) \equiv \mathbf{1}\{s_{i,t} > \kappa\}, \quad \kappa \in \{0.03, 0.05, 0.07\}. \quad (1)$$

Outcome. Let $A_{i,\tau}^c \in \{0, 1\}$ indicate that country i is classified as an autocracy in year τ under regime coding c :

$$A_{i,\tau}^{\text{V-Dem}} = \mathbf{1}\{v2x_regime_{i,\tau} \leq 1\}, \quad A_{i,\tau}^{\text{Polity}} = \mathbf{1}\{polity2_{i,\tau} < 6\}. \quad (2)$$

Under V-Dem Regimes of the World, $v2x_regime \leq 1$ marks an autocracy (closed or electoral); under Polity5, $polity2 < 6$ marks the loss of democratic status (autocracy or anocracy). The outcome is a forward-looking, ten-year transition indicator, defined only for elections at which the country is itself a democracy ($A_{i,t}^c = 0$):

$$Y_{i,t}^c = \mathbf{1}\left\{\sum_{h=1}^{10} A_{i,t+h}^c \geq 1\right\}, \quad \text{conditional on } A_{i,t}^c = 0. \quad (3)$$

That is, $Y_{i,t}^c = 1$ if the country becomes an autocracy in *any* of the ten years following the election, and 0 if it remains a democracy throughout. Elections at which the country is already autocratic, or for which the ten-year window is unobserved, are dropped; conditioning on $A_{i,t}^c = 0$ ensures the outcome captures a genuine democracy-to-autocracy transition.

Specification. For each predictor and each coding c , I estimate the logit

$$\Pr(Y_{i,t}^c = 1 \mid x_{i,t}) = \Lambda(\alpha + \beta x_{i,t}), \quad \Lambda(z) = \frac{e^z}{1 + e^z}, \quad (4)$$

where the single regressor $x_{i,t}$ is, in turn, the continuous share $s_{i,t}$ or one of the threshold indicators $T_{i,t}(\kappa)$. Each cell of Table 4 is therefore a separate single-regressor logit (eight in total: four predictor specifications $\times$ two regime codings). The coefficient β gives the change in the log-odds of a ten-year democracy-to-autocracy transition associated with the predictor; a positive, significant β means autocratic campaign rhetoric forecasts subsequent autocratization. Standard errors are clustered by country. The sample comprises Comparative Manifesto Project election winners over 1960–2024 whose country is coded as a democracy at the election year.

4.2 Estimating Causal Effects of Autocratic Leaders

My main specification is the local-projections difference-in-differences (LP-DiD) from Dube et al. (2025), which estimates dynamic treatment effects that are robust to the heterogeneous treatment timing known to bias conventional two-way fixed-effects designs (Goodman-Bacon 2021; De Chaisemartin and D’Haultfœuille 2020; De Chaisemartin and D’Haultfœuille 2026).

Unlike other commonly-used staggered DiD estimators, the LP-DiD can be customized to allow for one-off treatments, a feature favorable for our setting where observations can receive multiple treatments over the sample period.

Treatment. Let $s_{i,t}$ denote the share of quasi-sentences expressing autocratic rhetoric in the winning manifesto in country i 's election year t (and zero in non-election years). The baseline treatment is the binary indicator

$$D_{i,t} = \mathbf{1}[s_{i,t} > 0.05] \times \mathbf{1}[\text{challenger win}], \quad (5)$$

which equals one in the year a *non-incumbent* party wins office on a manifesto whose autocratic-rhetoric share exceeds five percent, and zero otherwise. The 0.05 cutoff falls in an empty region of the score distribution (between the mass points at 0.04 and 0.06), making the indicator insensitive to small scoring error; the challenger restriction isolates the entry of a new autocratic-mandate leader rather than the re-election of an established one.

Estimating equation. For each horizon $h \in \{-6, \dots, -2, 0, 1, \dots, 10\}$ and each outcome y , I estimate

$$y_{i,t+h} - y_{i,t-1} = \beta_h D_{i,t} + \sum_{\ell=1}^2 \phi_{h,\ell} \Delta y_{i,t-\ell} + \sum_{\ell=1}^2 \psi_{h,\ell} y_{i,t-\ell} + \gamma'_h z_{i,t} + \alpha_i^h + \delta_t^h + \varepsilon_{i,t}^h. \quad (6)$$

The dependent variable is the cumulative change in the outcome from the pre-treatment period $t - 1$ to horizon $t + h$, so that $h = -1$ is the omitted reference period, normalized to zero. The coefficient of interest, β_h , is the effect of an autocratic-mandate win on the outcome h years after the election. α_i^h and δ_t^h are horizon-specific country and year fixed effects, absorbing time-invariant country differences and common annual shocks. The terms $\Delta y_{i,t-1}$, $\Delta y_{i,t-2}$ and $y_{i,t-1}$, $y_{i,t-2}$ control for the pre-treatment dynamics and level of the outcome, ensuring that treated and control country-years are compared conditional on parallel pre-trends. The vector $z_{i,t}$ contains cross-outcome controls: for the Electoral Democracy Index I include the two lagged levels of Judicial Constraints on the Executive, and for Judicial Constraints I include the lagged level of the Electoral Democracy Index. At the horizons $h = -2$ and $h = -3$, where the dependent variable is mechanically related to a lagged difference, I include only the non-collinear subset of $\{\Delta y_{i,t-1}, \Delta y_{i,t-2}\}$.

Each horizon is estimated as a separate regression. The post-treatment coefficients $\{\beta_h\}_{h \geq 0}$ trace the dynamic response of the outcome, while the pre-treatment coefficients $\{\beta_h\}_{h < 0}$ serve as direct placebo tests: under parallel trends they should be statistically indistinguishable from zero. Standard errors are clustered at the country level. The estimation sample comprises Comparative Manifesto Project countries over 1960–2024.

Outcomes. I estimate equation (6) for two outcomes from the V-Dem project: the Electoral Democracy Index (*v2x_polyarchy*) and Judicial Constraints on the Executive (*v2x_jucon*). As a robustness check I re-estimate all specifications using the heterogeneity-robust estimator of De Chaisemartin and D'Haultfœuille (2020), which accommodates non-absorbing treatments and does not require a never-treated control group; results are reported in Section 5.

5 Results

5.1 Autocrats Before Autocracy

Table 4: Autocratic Rhetoric and Autocracy Onset within Ten Years

	(1) V-Dem ($\rightarrow$ autocracy)	(2) Polity5 ($\rightarrow$ non-democracy)
<i>Continuous</i>		
Autocratic share s	25.23*** (9.77)	36.51*** (10.18)
<i>Binary thresholds</i>		
$\mathbf{1}[s > 0.03]$	1.63** (0.82)	2.65*** (0.92)
$\mathbf{1}[s > 0.05]$	1.86** (0.85)	2.35*** (0.55)
$\mathbf{1}[s > 0.07]$	2.22** (0.86)	2.73*** (0.54)
Observations	503	431
Transitions	21	8

Each cell reports a separate unconditional logit; standard errors (in parentheses) clustered by country. The outcome equals one if the country, a democracy at the election year, exits democracy at any point within the following ten years: transitioning to autocracy under (1) V-Dem Regimes of the World ($v2x_regime \leq 1$), or losing democratic status under (2) Polity5 ($polity2 < 6$, which also captures the anocracy range). The predictor is the challenger-restricted autocratic-rhetoric share s (continuous) or a binary indicator that s exceeds the stated threshold. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table 5: Predicted Transition Probabilities and Marginal Effects

	V-Dem (→ autocracy)	Polity5 (→ non-democracy)
<i>Avg. marginal effect (continuous share)</i>		
per +1 p.p. of share	+0.97**	+0.63*
<i>Predicted Pr(transition within 10y)</i>		
$s > 0.03$: below / above	3.2% / 14.6%	1.0% / 12.5%
difference (pp)	+11.4**	+11.5***
$s > 0.05$: below / above	3.5% / 19.0%	1.4% / 13.3%
difference (pp)	+15.5**	+11.9***
$s > 0.07$: below / above	3.5% / 25.0%	1.4% / 18.2%
difference (pp)	+21.5**	+16.8***

Margins computed from the single-regressor logits of Table 4 (SE clustered by country). The continuous-share row reports the average marginal effect on the probability of a ten-year transition per one-percentage-point increase in the manifesto’s autocratic share. Each threshold block reports the predicted transition probability below versus above the cutoff and their difference (a saturated single-binary regressor, so these equal the group transition rates). Outcome and codings as in Table 4. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

The results in Tables 4 and 5 deliver a clear message: the autocratic-rhetoric share of a winning manifesto forecasts whether a country subsequently transitions out of democracy. The relationship is strong, monotone in the share, and statistically significant under two independent regime classifications. A winning party whose manifesto exceeds five percent autocratic content is associated with a nineteen percent probability of a democracy-to-autocracy transition within ten years, against a baseline of three and a half percent for parties below that cutoff — more than a fivefold increase in risk. The gap widens as the threshold rises, from eleven percentage points at the three-percent cutoff to twenty-one at the seven-percent cutoff, mirroring a dose-response pattern: the more a campaign is devoted to autocratic rhetoric, the more likely autocratization follows.

For the database, this establishes *predictive validity* — arguably the most demanding test a new measure can pass. The score is constructed entirely from campaign text, while the outcome is coded, years later and by separate research teams, from observed political institutions. The two share no common input, so their correlation is not a mechanical artifact of how the measure is built. That an ex-ante reading of what parties *say* predicts what independent observers later record about regime type is direct evidence that the measure captures a real, latent propensity toward autocratic rule, rather than rhetorical noise. It validates the project’s central premise: autocrats are legible before autocracy, and their campaign manifestos carry forward-looking information about the institutional trajectories that follow.

Hugo Chávez is the clean illustration of this predictability. He did not disguise his program in 1998; the constituent assembly and the refounding of the state were the campaign, not a later improvisation, and Levitsky and Ziblatt (2019) treat Venezuela as the archetype of

the elected leader who telegraphs autocratization before enacting it. The measure developed here reads such telegraphed intent systematically and at scale, rather than case by case in hindsight.

The robustness of the result across the V-Dem and Polity classifications matters for the same reason. These datasets are built on different methodologies and different thresholds — V-Dem’s categorical Regimes of the World versus Polity’s twenty-one-point composite — yet both register the same predictive content. The measure is therefore not tracking the idiosyncrasies of any single coding scheme; it is picking up a signal of autocratization that is visible however one chooses to draw the line between democracy and its absence.

The dose-response structure further indicates that the measure carries *cardinal*, not merely *ordinal*, information. The continuous share is a significant predictor in its own right — each additional percentage point of autocratic rhetoric raises the ten-year transition probability by roughly one percentage point under V-Dem — and the binary indicators inherit that signal at every threshold. This justifies the two ways the measure is used in the analysis that follows: as a continuous treatment intensity, and as a binary indicator at a transparent cutoff.

Table 6: Autocratic-Mandate Wins and New-Constitution Adoption

	Within 5y (New constitution event)	Within 10y (New constitution event)
<i>Panel A. Logit coefficients (log-odds)</i>		
Autocratic share s	+12.75 (9.25)	+9.32 (9.03)
$\mathbf{1}[s > 0.03]$	+0.53 (0.68)	+0.25 (0.69)
$\mathbf{1}[s > 0.05]$	+1.29* (0.74)	+0.99 (0.74)
$\mathbf{1}[s > 0.07]$	+1.65** (0.73)	+1.37* (0.74)
<i>Panel B. Predicted probabilities & marginal effects</i>		
AME, per +1 p.p. of share	+0.42	+0.50
$s > 0.03$: below / above difference (pp)	3.3% / 5.4% +2.1	5.6% / 7.1% +1.5
$s > 0.05$: below / above difference (pp)	3.1% / 10.5% +7.4*	5.4% / 13.3% +7.9
$s > 0.07$: below / above difference (pp)	3.1% / 14.3% +11.2**	5.4% / 18.2% +12.8*
N	435	365
Events (= 1)	15	21

Each column is the indicated horizon; the unit is a CMP-winner election. Panel A reports separate single-regressor logits (one regressor at a time: the continuous autocratic share s , or a binary $\mathbf{1}[s > \tau]$), with standard errors clustered by country in parentheses. Panel B reports the average marginal effect on $\Pr(\text{new constitution})$ per one-percentage-point of share, and, for each threshold, the predicted probability below / above the cutoff and their difference (a saturated single-binary regressor, so these equal the group rates). The outcome is the CCP *Chronology of Constitutional Events* indicator that ≥ 1 **new** (adoption/replacement) event occurs within the window; elections without a fully observable window are dropped (right-censoring). * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Constitutional rewriting. I next ask whether autocratic-mandate winners move to rewrite the constitutional order itself, using the Comparative Constitutions Project’s Chronology of Constitutional Events (Elkins and Ginsburg 2026). The CCP defines a constitutional system as “the period in which a constitution is in force, a period bracketed by the year of adoption and that of any replacement or suspension,” and a constitutional event as “any change to a country’s constitution, including adoption, amendment, suspension, or reinstatement”; the chronology is “a comprehensive listing of the year of constitutional adoption, replacement, and amendment for all independent states since 1789.” Our outcome indicates whether at least one new event — a constitutional adoption/replacement that begins a new system — occurs within five (ten) years of the election. I estimate a pooled, single-regressor logit at

the election level with standard errors clustered by country, and report both coefficients and predicted probabilities in Table 6. The estimates show that autocratic-mandate winners are far more likely to replace the constitution. Conditioning on the $s > 0.07$ threshold, the predicted probability of adopting a new constitution within five years rises from 3.1% among other election winners to 14.3% — a difference of 11.2 percentage points ($p < 0.05$; log-odds +1.65) — with a comparable jump at $s > 0.05$ (3.1% to 10.5%, +7.4pp, $p < 0.10$) and a monotone dose-response across thresholds. The effect is front-loaded: within ten years the contrast attenuates in significance (e.g. $s > 0.07$: 5.4% to 18.2%, log-odds +1.37, $p < 0.10$), consistent with newly empowered leaders rewriting the constitution quickly while the comparison group’s ordinary constitutional turnover catches up over the longer horizon. New constitutions are rare (15 and 21 events across the 435 and 365 elections with observable windows), so power is limited and the result is sharpest at the higher thresholds; nonetheless, because the CCP records constitutional replacement from primary sources independent of the V-Dem expert coders, it corroborates the institutional-erosion findings with an objective behavioral measure. These results reflect Hugo Chávez’s 1999 constitution and Orbán’s 2011 Fundamental Law, emblematic instances, each recasting the formal order early, while the mandate was fresh, to lock in an advantage that ordinary legislation could not. That the constitutional effect in my estimates is front-loaded, concentrated in the first years after the election, matches this logic exactly.

Two cautions delimit what this exercise does and does not show. First, it is predictive, not causal. The logits document that autocratic-platform winners preside over autocratization more often; they do not establish that the leader *caused* it, since such parties may win precisely where democratic institutions were already fragile. Disentangling the two is the task of the difference-in-differences design in Section 4, for which this validation is a precondition rather than a substitute. Second, autocratization is rare, so even the elevated probabilities remain well below one half: a high autocratic-rhetoric score sharply raises the risk of a transition without making it inevitable. The measure relocates a country along the risk distribution; it does not forecast its fate. With those qualifications, the exercise accomplishes what it sets out to do — it shows that the database identifies, from campaign language alone, the leaders under whom democracies are most likely to fall.

5.2 Autocrats and Democratic Backsliding

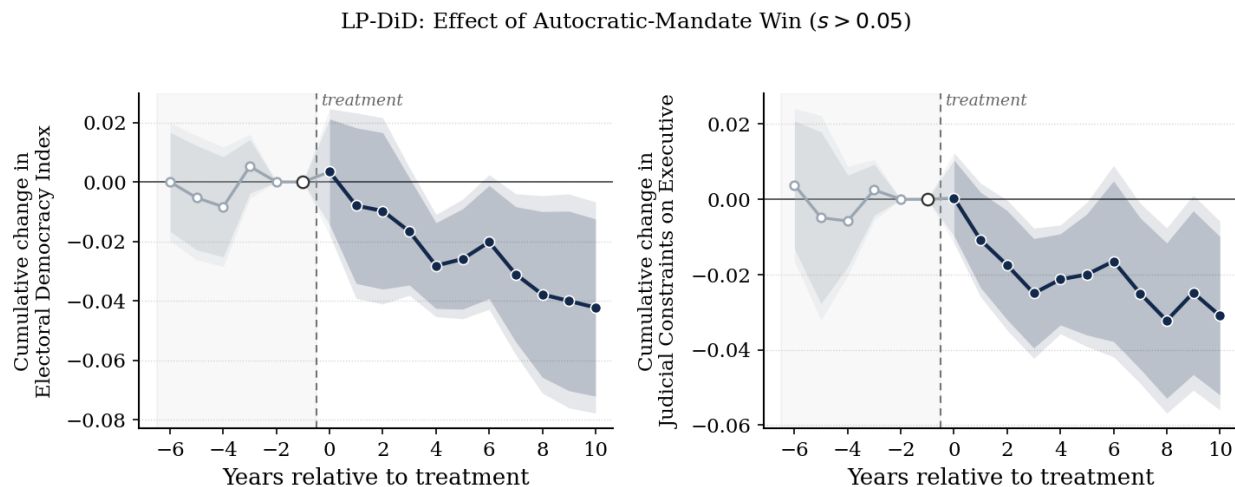


Figure 2: Baseline LP-DiD — Effect of an Autocratic Leader Coming into Power on Democratic Institutions

Figure 2 presents the baseline LP-DiD estimates of the effect of an autocratic-mandate win ($s > 0.05$) on the two headline outcomes. Two features stand out. First, the pre-treatment coefficients are small and statistically indistinguishable from zero (the largest pre-period t -statistic is below one), so treated and control countries are on parallel trajectories before the election—the identifying assumption is not rejected. Second, following the election both indices decline steadily and cumulatively. The Electoral Democracy Index falls by 0.042 index points by the tenth year (s.e. = 0.018), and Judicial Constraints on the Executive by 0.031 points (s.e. = 0.013); both are significant at the 5% level, and the decline grows monotonically over the horizon rather than reverting. Institutions bend at the moment of the shock and erode progressively thereafter, consistent with guardrails that constrain a new leader initially but are worn down over time.

Tautological versus Non-Tautological Treatment

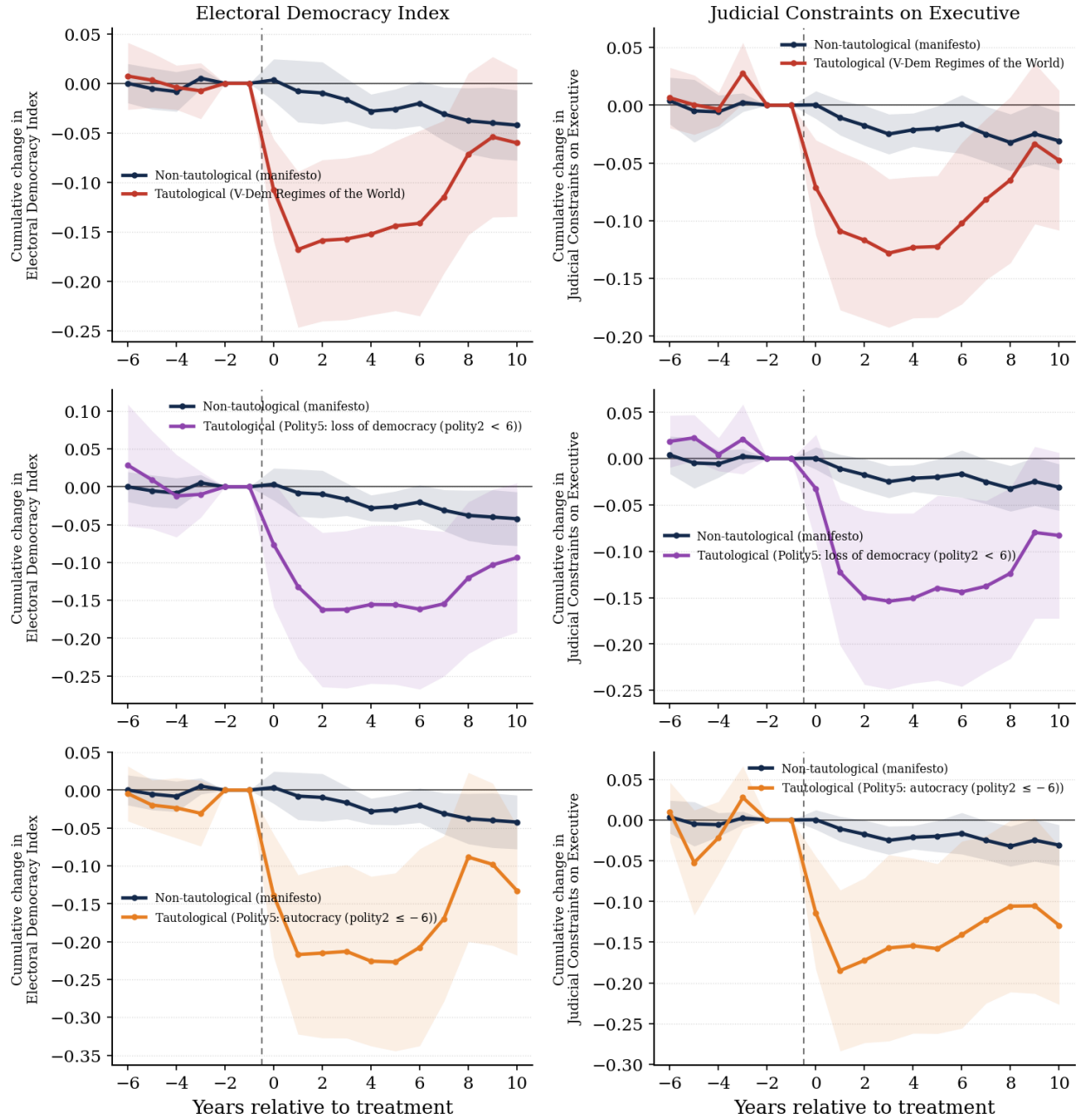


Figure 3: LP-DiD — Tautological versus Non-Tautological Treatment

Comparing these main results to estimates from the same model but with tautological treatment reveals that the rhetoric-based ex-ante treatment better captures democratic backsliding’s “piece-meal” decline. For tautological measures of autocracy transition, I use V-Dem and Polity5’s traditional markers. The tautological estimates show a consistent and clear large step effect and slow and gradual recovery from an autocratization shock. This is expected as the treatment itself is endogenous on the outcome. These results show a clear

advantage that the rhetoric-based treatment has: the ex-ante definition, undetermined by the outcome, has the ability to capture the slow backsliding the political science literature describes.

LP-DiD: Effect of Autocratic-Mandate Win ($s > 0.07$)

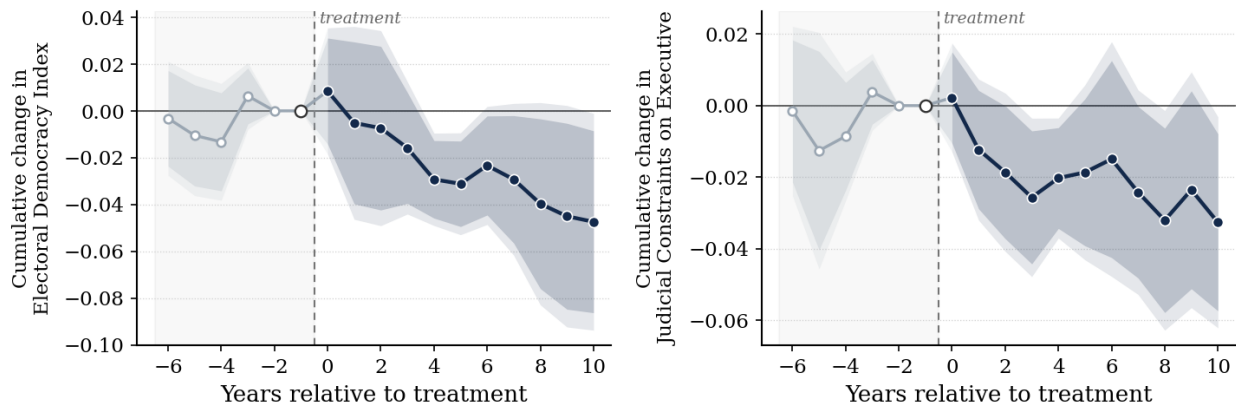


Figure 4: LP-DiD — 0.07 Threshold

LP-DiD: Effect of Autocratic-Mandate Win ($s > 0.03$)

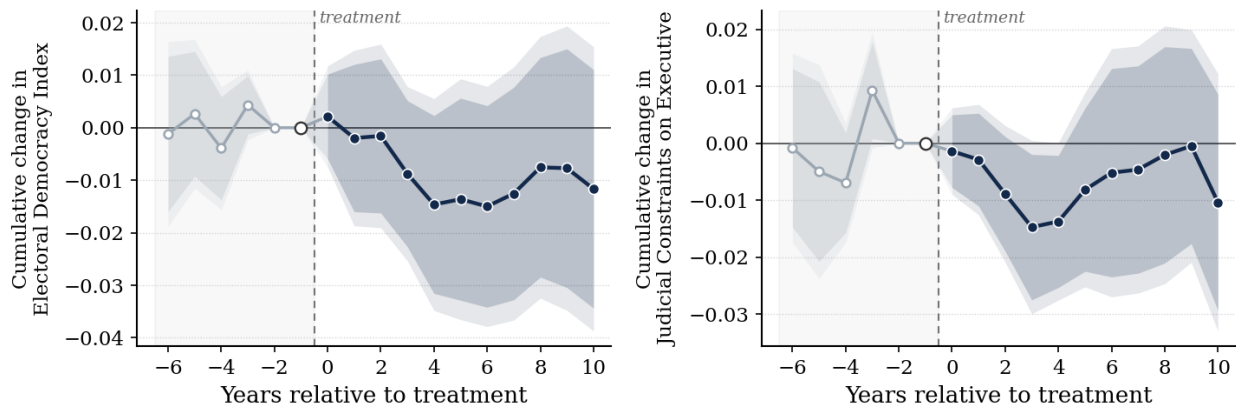


Figure 5: LP-DiD — 0.03 Threshold

The results are robust to the treatment threshold and to the estimator, and it displays a dose-response pattern. Raising the binary cutoff strengthens the effect: at $s > 0.07$ the ten-year declines are larger still (Figure 4; -0.047 for electoral democracy and -0.033 for judicial constraints, both significant at 5%), while at the most permissive cutoff $s > 0.03$ the estimates retain the same sign but shrink toward zero and lose significance (Figure 5)—as expected, since the lowest threshold admits the most marginal, and most error-prone, manifestos. The more a campaign is devoted to autocratic rhetoric, the larger the subsequent institutional erosion.

DcDH: Effect of Autocratic-Mandate Win ($s > 0.05$)

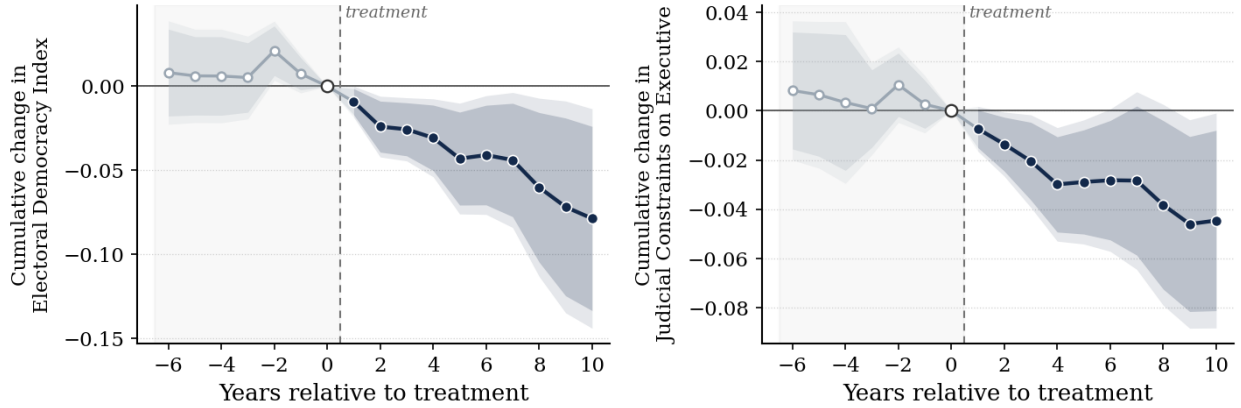


Figure 6: dCDH — Effect of an Autocratic Leader Coming into Power on Democratic Institutions

I replicate every specification with the heterogeneity-robust estimator of De Chaisemartin and D'Haultfœuille (2020). The DcDH estimates confirm the LP-DiD findings and are, if anything, larger in magnitude: at $s > 0.05$ the ten-year effects are -0.079 for electoral democracy and -0.045 for judicial constraints, both significant at 5%. The heterogeneity-robust results remain robust with the 3% and 7% thresholds and are even more significant than their LP-DiD counterparts (see Appendix B).

Mechanisms of Judicial Capture (LP-DiD, $s > 0.05$)

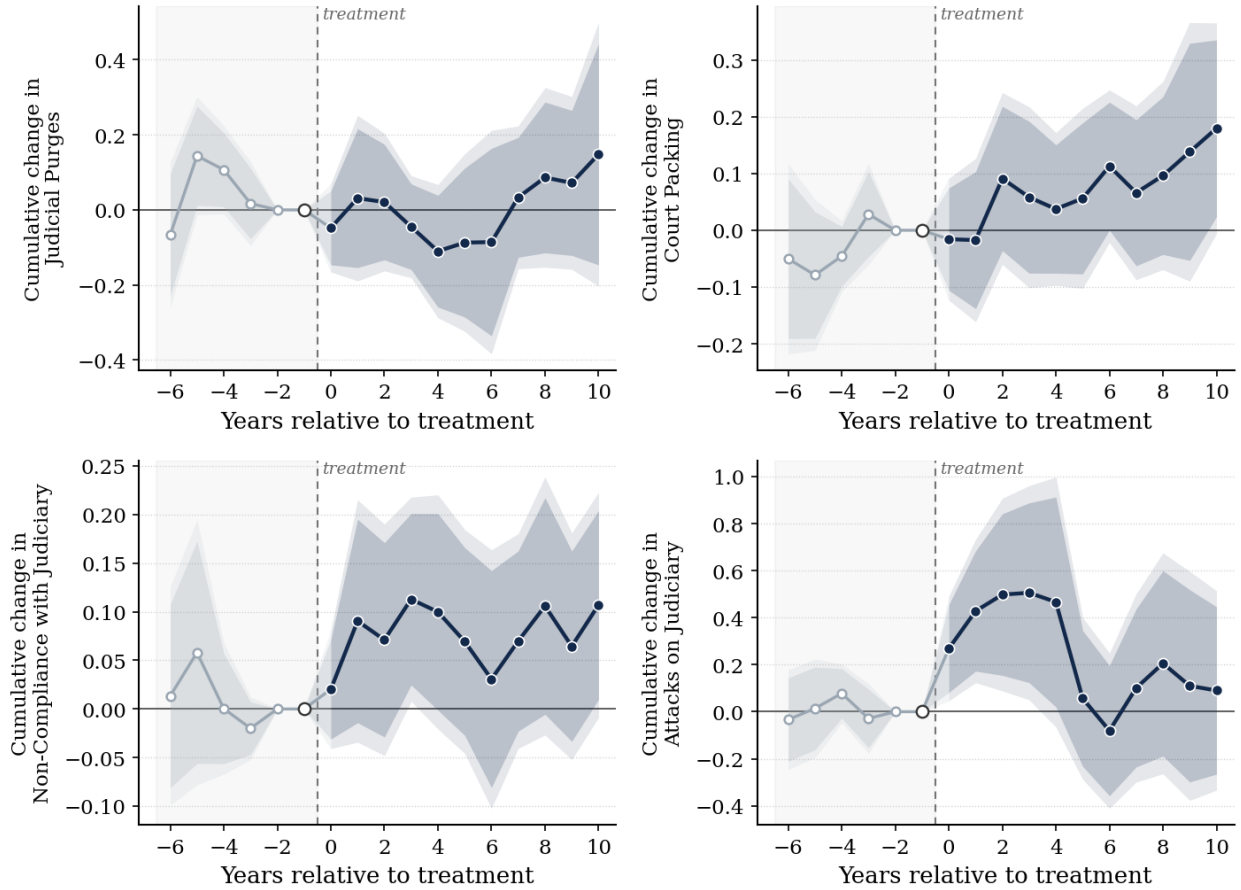


Figure 7: LP-DiD — Effect of an Autocratic Leader Coming into Power on the Judicial System

Judiciary. To open the black box of judicial erosion, Figure 7 estimates the same design on four specific channels coded by V-Dem: judicial purges, court packing, executive non-compliance with the judiciary, and physical attacks on the judiciary. The clearest and most robust channel is *executive non-compliance*: it rises significantly and persistently, indicating that autocratic-mandate governments increasingly disregard adverse court rulings. *Court packing* also increases, significant at the 10% level in the LP-DiD. *Attacks on the judiciary* show a large, significant spike in the first few post-election years that subsequently fades. *Judicial purges*, by contrast, are positively signed but imprecisely estimated and not statistically significant at conventional levels. The evidence therefore points to non-compliance and court packing—rather than outright purges—as the operative mechanisms through which these governments subordinate the courts.

As highlighted in Levitsky and Ziblatt (2019), the successful version of an autocrat taking over the judiciary is Juan Perón, who in 1947 had Argentina’s Congress impeach three of the five Supreme Court justices and remade the bench in his image. The instructive failure is Franklin Roosevelt, whose 1937 plan to add up to six justices to a hostile Supreme Court

was killed in the Senate by members of his own party: the institution, and the norm of forbearance around it, held. My estimates locate the modern pattern between these poles and closer to Perón, but with a characteristic twist. Today’s autocrats rarely need Perón’s overt impeachment; the operative channels are quieter, non-compliance with adverse rulings and gradual packing, which is why outright purges of sitting judges, the most visible instrument, barely register in the data.

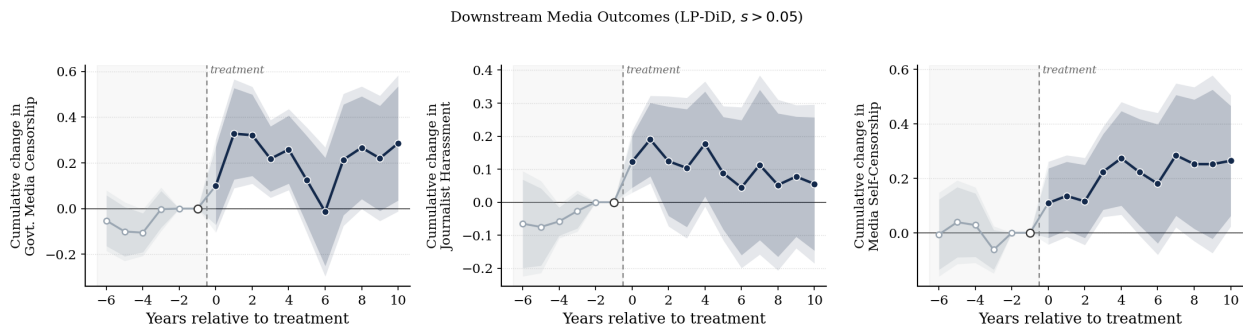


Figure 8: LP-DiD — Effect of an Autocratic Leader Coming into Power on the Media

Media. Finally, Figure 8 examines whether the same shock propagates beyond the judiciary into the media. It does. Government media censorship and media self-censorship both rise significantly and persistently following an autocratic-mandate win. Harassment of journalists increases sharply in the first year or two but is imprecisely estimated at longer horizons. The pattern is consistent with the view that once the judiciary can no longer constrain the executive, the cost of pressuring the press falls, and that judicial capture is an enabling step toward broader control of the information environment rather than an isolated outcome. As with the institutional outcomes, a few of the media placebo coefficients are marginally significant, so these downstream estimates are best read as indicative of direction and persistence rather than precise magnitudes. This is what Levitsky and Ziblatt (2019) calls “sidelining the players.” Its methods range from Fujimori’s intelligence chief bribing Peru’s television stations to Chávez’s refusal to renew the license of the country’s oldest private broadcaster. The cross-national pattern here is subtler than either but points the same way: once the courts can no longer constrain the executive, the cost of pressuring the press falls, and censorship and self-censorship rise together.

5.3 Robustness Checks

LP-DiD long horizon ($s > 0.05$): placebos to -10 , effects to $+20$

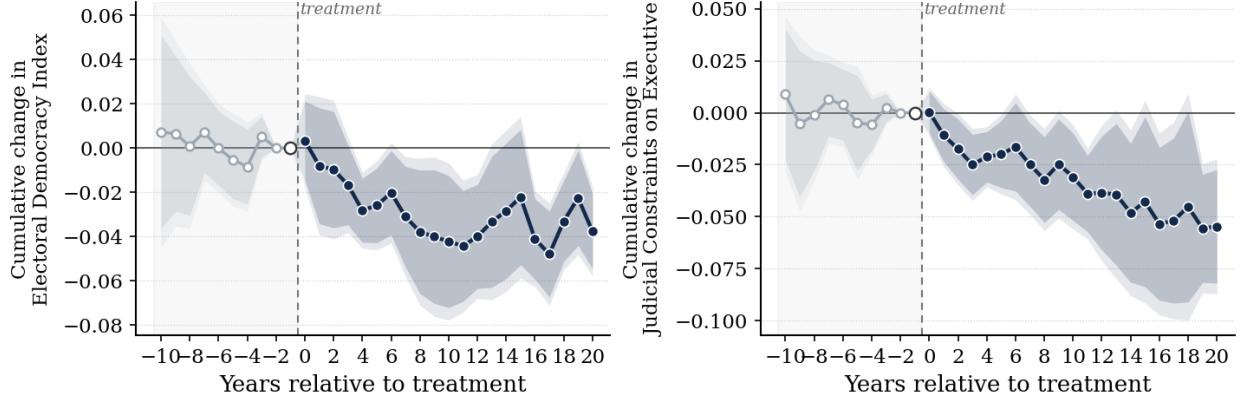


Figure 9: LP-DiD — Long Horizon Baseline

Long-run effects. To gauge persistence and probe the parallel-trends assumption over a wider window, I re-estimate the baseline specification ($s > 0.05$) extending the placebo horizons to ten years before the election and the effect horizons to twenty years after, shown in Figure 9. The pre-treatment coefficients remain flat and statistically indistinguishable from zero out to $h = -10$, reinforcing the identifying assumption. Post-treatment, the institutional erosion persists and, if anything, deepens over the long run: the effect on electoral democracy remains negative through two decades (-0.038 at $h = 20$), and judicial constraints decline steadily to their largest estimate at the longest horizon (-0.055 at $h = 20$). I caution that the fifteen- and twenty-year estimates rest only on the early treated cohorts observable that far out — the panel ends in 2024, so any country treated after 2004 drops from the longest horizons — which widens their standard errors and renders the path non-monotonic. I therefore read the long horizons as suggestive of durable, non-reverting erosion rather than as precisely estimated effects.

Leave-one-treated-country-out jackknife (LP-DiD, $s > 0.05$)

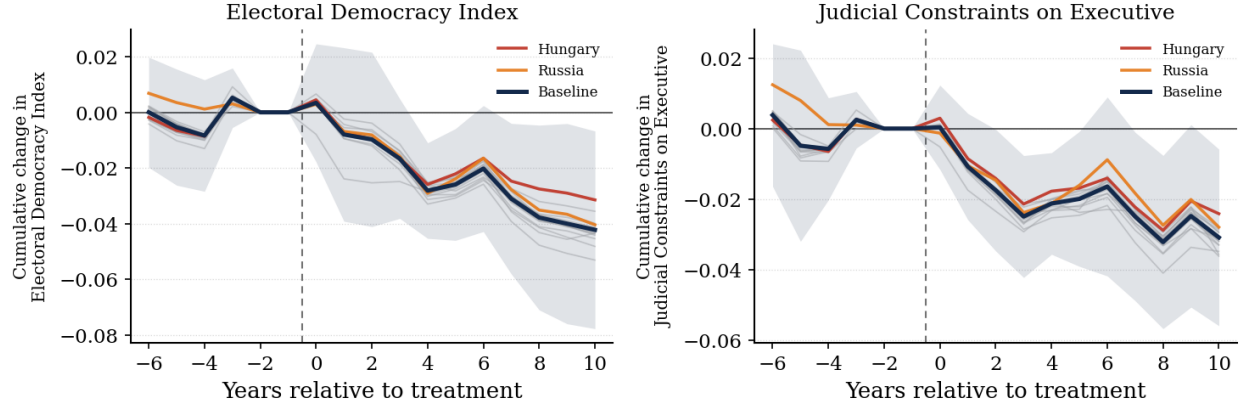


Figure 10: LP-DiD — Jackknife of Baseline

One-out sample. Because only 18 countries are ever treated at the baseline threshold, I confirm the result is not driven by any single case with a leave-one-out jackknife, re-estimating the baseline specification while dropping each treated country in turn. Figure 10 plots all eighteen jackknife paths against the baseline. Each panel re-estimates the event study dropping one treated country at a time (18 gray paths); the full-sample baseline is in navy with its 95% confidence band. Paths for Hungary and Russia excluded are highlighted. The estimates are highly stable: across all 18 exclusions the ten-year effect on electoral democracy ranges from -0.053 to -0.032 (baseline -0.042) and on judicial constraints from -0.036 to -0.024 (baseline -0.031), always retaining its sign. The most influential single case is Hungary, but excluding it still leaves a clear negative effect -0.032 and -0.024 , respectively). The post-treatment trajectory is stable across all exclusions, indicating no single country drives the effect.

Autocracy versus populism. The political science literature has debated the importance of distinguishing populism and autocrats. They are certainly overlapping in definition. This section estimates the impacts of the two classifications of leaders to see if they are really that different. The primary results are robust to an alternative, independent definition of treatment. Re-estimating with the Funke et al. (2023) populist classification² — which flags largely different leaders (only 5 of 24 overlap) — yields a similar, if somewhat larger, erosion path (see Appendix C).

Controlling for the economy I add two economics control variables: two lags of the first difference log real gdp per capita and inflation. The results dim slightly but still remain significant, still showing a slow decline in democratic institutions (See appendix D).

²Funke et al. (2023) classify populist leaders using both ex-ante and ex-post definitions that are based on populist rhetoric and are expert coded. They are not based on actions regarding democratic systems.

6 Conclusion

Establishing whether autocratic leaders *cause* the institutions meant to constrain them to erode has long been frustrated by a measurement problem: classifying a leader as autocratic on the basis of what they do in office builds the outcome into the treatment. This paper proposes a way around that circularity. Using the language of campaign manifestos, scored by a large language model for the share of content devoted to autocratic rhetoric across six dimensions drawn from Levitsky and Ziblatt (2019) and V-Dem, I construct an ex-ante measure of executive autocratic tendencies that is logically prior to any institutional outcome and drawn from a source entirely independent of the regime indices it is used to explain. Because a manifesto is written and scored before a single court is packed or a single election contested, “ran on an authoritarian platform” and “later subverted the courts” remain distinct, separately measured events.

The measure passes a demanding external test. The autocratic-rhetoric share of a winning manifesto forecasts whether a country subsequently transitions out of democracy within a decade, under both V-Dem and Polity5, two classifications built on different methodologies that share no input with the text. The relationship is strong, monotone across thresholds, and carries cardinal information: a party campaigning above five percent autocratic content faces roughly a nineteen percent probability of a democracy-to-autocracy transition, against a baseline near three and a half percent. That an ex-ante reading of what parties *say* predicts what independent observers later record about regime type is direct evidence that the measure captures a real, latent propensity toward autocratic rule rather than rhetorical noise.

Equipped with this treatment, I estimate the dynamic effect of installing an autocratic-mandate leader using local-projections difference-in-differences and the heterogeneity-robust estimator of De Chaisemartin and D’Haultfoeulle (2020). Democratic institutions do not collapse at the moment such a leader takes office; they erode gradually and cumulatively over the following decade, and the decline shows no sign of reverting. Extended to a twenty-year window, both electoral democracy and judicial constraints on the executive remain depressed, with judicial constraints continuing to deteriorate at the longest horizons. The flat pre-trends, the dose-response strengthening of the effect with the intensity of the rhetoric campaigned on, and a leave-one-country-out jackknife that survives the exclusion of even the most-cited case, Hungary, together rule out the most obvious alternative explanations.

The value of measuring autocratic intent *before* it is realized comes into sharpest relief when the same dynamic design is re-run with a conventional, ex-post definition of treatment. Tautological markers, which code a country as treated when V-Dem or Polity already records its transition, produce a large discrete step at the moment of the shock followed by gradual recovery, exactly the artifact one expects when the treatment is read from the same observers as the outcome. The rhetoric-based treatment, undetermined by the outcome, instead recovers the slow, non-reverting “piecemeal” erosion that the political science literature describes. The contrast is not a robustness footnote but the empirical payoff of the non-tautological design: only a treatment defined independently of the institutional record can trace backsliding as it actually unfolds.

Decomposing the judicial effect into specific channels shows that these governments sub-

ordinate the courts not through the dramatic purges that dominate the popular image of autocratic takeover, but through quieter means: executive non-compliance with adverse rulings and court packing, with outright dismissal of sitting judges positively signed but imprecisely estimated. The same shock propagates beyond the judiciary into the information environment, raising government media censorship and media self-censorship and, in the first years, the harassment of journalists. Judicial capture is thus an enabling step toward broader control rather than an isolated outcome. On one margin the process moves fast: drawing on the Comparative Constitutions Project’s primary-source record, again independent of the V-Dem coders, autocratic-mandate winners sharply raise the probability of adopting an entirely new constitution, with the effect front-loaded in the years just after the election. Newly empowered leaders rewrite the formal rules early, while they hold the mandate to do so, and then use the resulting architecture to hollow out democratic practice gradually thereafter. Together these results portray autocratization as a slow, institutionally mediated campaign in which formal guardrails restrain a new leader at first but are progressively worn down.

The measure also speaks to a long-running debate over whether “autocrat” and “populist” name the same phenomenon. Re-estimating the dynamic effects with the independent, expert-coded populist classification of Funke et al. (2023), which flags a largely different set of leaders, yields a similar erosion path; but the two concepts are not interchangeable. The autocratic-rhetoric measure isolates the institutional-erosion content of a platform directly, where populism captures it only insofar as the two coincide.

Several limitations remain and define the agenda for refining the measure. It reads stated intent from text, and campaign language is a probabilistic rather than deterministic signal of subsequent behavior; it distinguishes genuinely reformist platforms from autocratic ones only imperfectly, since the rhetoric of anti-corruption and institutional renewal is common to both. Zelensky’s 2019 platform, which scores high on language lexically close to judicial capture, is the cleanest illustration. And while the design conditions on observed covariates and fixed effects, leaders who win on such platforms are not randomly assigned; a fully exogenous source of variation, such as close-election outcomes, together with the blind human validation of the manifesto scores now underway, would sharpen the causal interpretation and bound the measure’s error rate. Both are incorporated in subsequent versions of this paper.

The broader contribution is to show that the institutions of democracy are visible in the language of those who would erode them, before the erosion occurs. That the words of a campaign forecast the fate of a country’s courts, constitution, and elections a decade later suggests that democratic backsliding is, to a meaningful degree, announced in advance, and that taking such announcements seriously is both possible and empirically warranted.

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A LLM Scoring Prompts

This appendix reproduces the three prompts used in the manifesto-scoring pipeline (Section 3.2). Each is supplied to Claude Haiku 4.5 (claude-haiku-4-5) at temperature zero as the scoring instruction, with the manifesto text appended where each prompt ends (MANIFESTO TEXT:). The dimension definitions and direction check in Pass 3 are identical to Pass 2 and are elided to save space.

A.1 Pass 1 — Loose Binary Screen

MANIFESTO SCREENING PROMPT -- PASS 1 (BINARY SCREEN)

Economics research project: democratic backsliding and institutional erosion

Model: claude-haiku-4-5-20251001 | Temperature: 0

You are a research assistant screening election manifestos for an economics study of democratic backsliding.

Read the following election manifesto carefully. It may be in any language.

Your task is a LOOSE BINARY SCREEN. You are NOT scoring autocratic severity -- that happens in a second stage. You are only deciding whether the manifesto warrants closer examination.

FLAG 1 (send to detailed scoring) if the manifesto contains ANY of the following, even weakly or in passing:

- Language framing political opponents, the judiciary, the media, or civil society as corrupt, illegitimate, criminal, or enemies of the people
- Rhetoric implying that only this party or leader represents the true will of the nation or the people
- Calls for strong, decisive, or unobstructed executive leadership
- Criticism of institutional arrangements (courts, electoral bodies, oversight agencies, constitutional constraints) as ineffective, captured, or in need of fundamental reform
- Nationalist or patriotic framing that identifies internal enemies (elites, minorities, foreign agents, the old regime)
- Proposals to change the composition, mandate, or independence of courts, media regulators, electoral commissions, or prosecutorial bodies
- Anti-corruption rhetoric framed as a mandate to restructure or bypass existing institutions

FLAG 0 (no further scoring needed) ONLY IF:

- The manifesto is an entirely standard policy platform -- economic, social, environmental -- with no political identity framing whatsoever
- The manifesto explicitly and unambiguously commits to strengthening judicial independence, press freedom, and electoral integrity as primary goals

IMPORTANT: When in doubt, flag 1. A false positive at this stage costs little -- the second stage will assign low proportions if the signal is weak or

misdirected. A false negative permanently sets all dimension scores to zero.
Do not let uncertainty produce a 0.

Respond with JSON only. No other text before or after.
{`"label": <0 or 1>, "summary": "<one sentence in English identifying the
signal present, or confirming its complete absence>"`}

MANIFESTO TEXT:

A.2 Pass 2 — Overall Autocratic Share

MANIFESTO SCORING PROMPT -- v4 PASS 3 (OVERALL AUTOCRATIC RHETORIC SHARE)
Economics research project: democratic backsliding and institutional erosion
Model: claude-haiku-4-5-20251001 | Temperature: 0

You are a research assistant scoring election manifestos for an economics study
of democratic backsliding.

This manifesto has been flagged as potentially containing autocratic rhetoric.
Read it carefully and estimate what PROPORTION of the manifesto's content is
devoted to autocratic rhetoric of ANY kind across the six dimensions below.

Your scoring framework is grounded in two sources:

- (1) Levitsky & Ziblatt (2018) "How Democracies Die" -- four behavioural indicators of autocratic parties.
- (2) V-Dem's conceptualisation of autocratization -- emphasising judicial independence, executive constraints, electoral integrity, and civil society as the institutional channels through which democracies erode.

Think of the manifesto as composed of N quasi-sentences -- units each expressing a single political idea (roughly one clause). Estimate the share of those units (0.00-1.00) that contain autocratic rhetoric belonging to ANY of the following six dimensions. This is a UNION measure -- a quasi-sentence counts once even if it touches multiple dimensions simultaneously.

Use genuine decimal variation: 0.03, 0.17, 0.24 are all valid. Avoid rounding to 0.00 or 1.00 unless autocratic rhetoric is genuinely absent or the entire manifesto is consumed by it. A manifesto with occasional autocratic rhetoric might score 0.03-0.08; a manifesto where it is a sustained theme might score 0.20-0.35.

DIMENSION DEFINITIONS

D1 | OPPONENT DELEGITIMIZATION [L&Z indicator 2]

Content that denies the fundamental legitimacy of political opponents, framing them not as policy rivals but as criminals, traitors, foreign agents, enemies of the people, or an existential threat to the nation. Includes: portraying any

future electoral loss as fraud or sabotage; framing the party as the only authentic representative of the national will; dehumanizing rhetoric about opponents or minorities.

Does NOT include: ordinary partisan criticism of policy positions or records.

D2 | REJECTION OF DEMOCRATIC RULES / POWER CONCENTRATION [L&Z indicator 1]

Content proposing to expand executive authority at the expense of constitutional checks and balances | removing or weakening oversight bodies, bypassing parliament, concentrating power in the executive or the party. Includes: calls to extend term limits, abolish independent agencies, restructure the central bank or electoral commission, rewrite the constitution to entrench the party's hold on power, or override institutional constraints in the name of national will or efficiency.

Does NOT include: calls for decisive or efficient government that do not target specific institutional constraints.

D3 | INTIMIDATION AND VIOLENCE [L&Z indicator 3]

Content that tolerates, encourages, or implicitly endorses violence or intimidation against political opponents, journalists, judges, or minorities. Includes: condoning or praising attacks on opponents; threats of prosecution or persecution framed as settling scores; rhetoric that portrays opponents as so dangerous that extreme measures are warranted; ties to or praise of paramilitary or vigilante groups.

Does NOT include: standard law-and-order rhetoric about crime unrelated to political opponents.

D4 | MEDIA AND CIVIL SOCIETY SUPPRESSION [L&Z indicator 4]

Content attacking independent media, NGOs, or civil society organisations as corrupt, foreign-funded, or enemies of the nation | and/or calling to regulate, restrict, defund, license, or subordinate them to state or party control.

Includes: threats of legal action against critical outlets; calls to revoke broadcast licences; framing civil society as a foreign-financed fifth column.

Does NOT include: general media criticism or calls for balanced coverage without proposing institutional control.

D5 | JUDICIAL CAPTURE [V-Dem: judicial independence, executive constraints]

Content that specifically attacks, delegitimizes, or calls to restructure courts, judges, prosecutors, or rule-of-law institutions | framing them as corrupt, captured by enemies, or biased against the party, and requiring reform under the party's control. Includes: calls to pack or purge courts, remove or discipline judges, override rulings, subordinate prosecutors to the executive, or redesign constitutional courts to favour the party.

Does NOT include: support for judicial reforms that strengthen independence; anti-corruption pledges not directed at judicial bodies as such.

D6 | ELECTORAL SUBVERSION [V-Dem: electoral integrity]

Content that undermines confidence in electoral institutions or proposes changes to electoral rules that would benefit the party's hold on power. Includes: advance claims that any loss would be the result of fraud; calls to restructure electoral commissions or change electoral rules in ways that favour the party; rhetoric framing elections as legitimate only if the party wins; proposals to restrict suffrage or exclude opponents from competition.

Does NOT include: genuine electoral reform proposals that strengthen fairness and independence; calls for better voter ID that are not framed as suppressing

specific opponents.

DIRECTION CHECK -- READ BEFORE SCORING

Score above 0.00 ONLY when the rhetoric is directed at SEIZING control of institutions for the party's own benefit once in office.

AUTOMATICALLY SCORES 0.00:

- An opposition coalition explicitly formed to reverse democratic erosion caused by the current government
 - Anti-corruption rhetoric directed at named individuals or past conduct -- not at institutions as such
 - A party that defends judicial independence, press freedom, or electoral integrity as constraints that would hold ITSELF accountable once in power
-

Respond with JSON only. No other text before or after.

{"autocratic_share": <0.00-1.00>, "reasoning": "<one sentence identifying the main autocratic content present across any of the six dimensions, and confirming the direction check>"}

MANIFESTO TEXT:

B Thresholds with Heterogeneity-robust Estimator

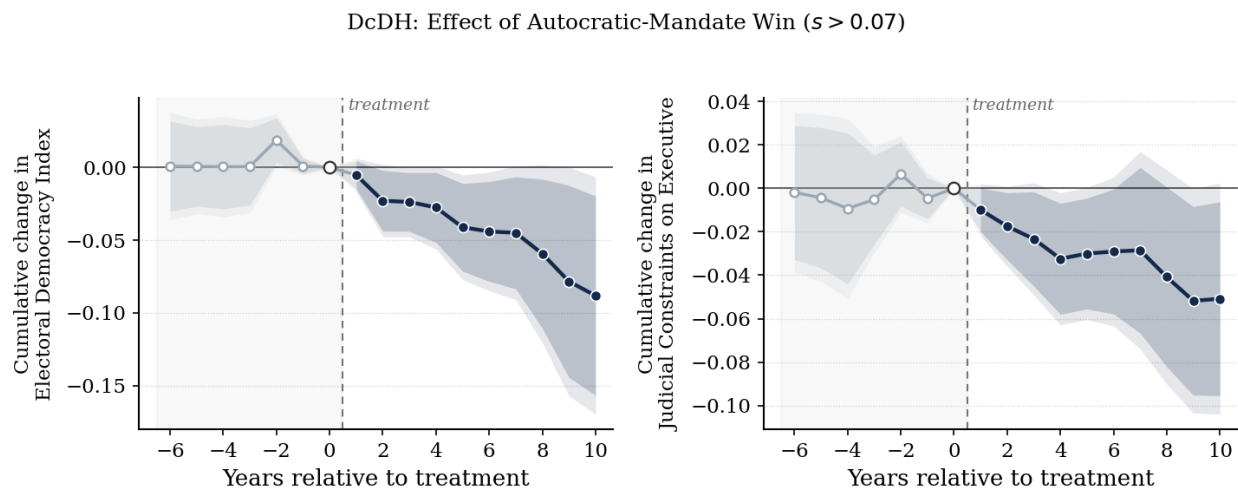


Figure 11: dCDH — 0.07 Threshold

DcDH: Effect of Autocratic-Mandate Win ($s > 0.03$)

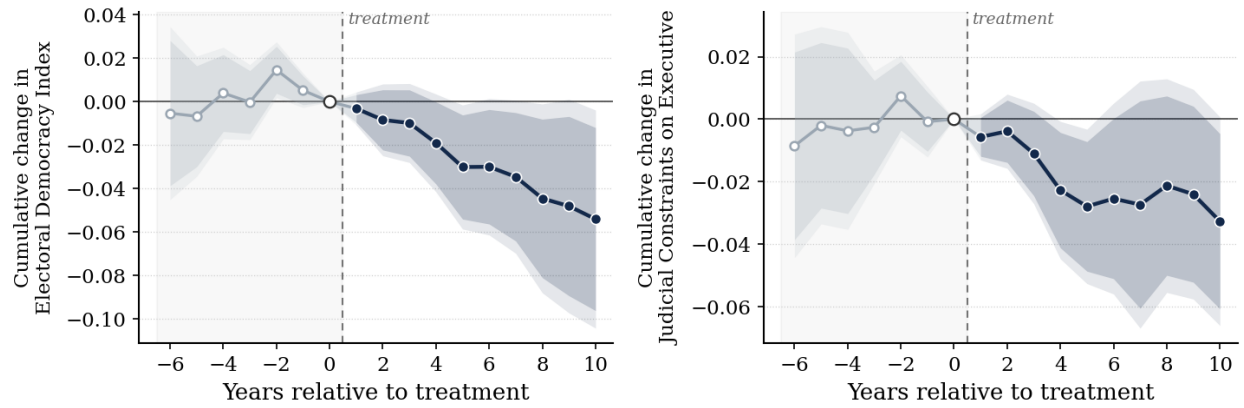


Figure 12: dCDH — 0.03 Threshold

C Autocrats Versus Populists

Autocrats versus Populists

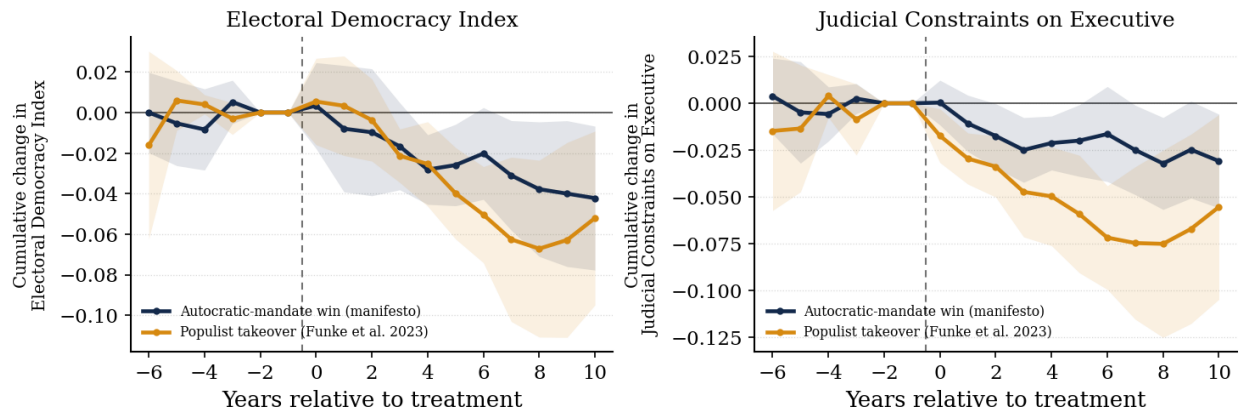


Figure 13: LP-DiD — Autocrat Versus Populist Treatments

D Baseline with Economic Controls

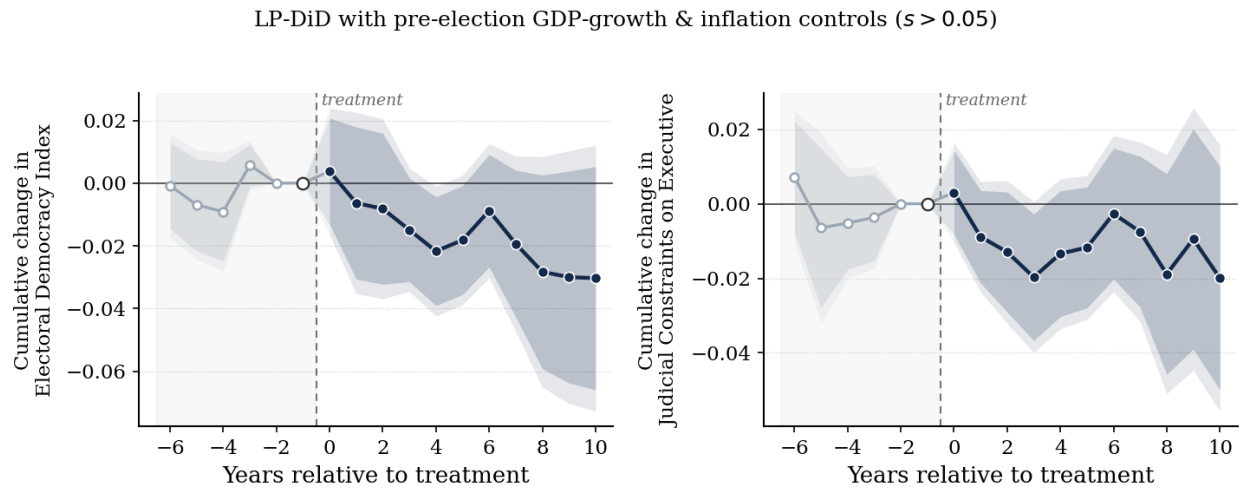


Figure 14: LP-DiD — Baseline plus economic controls